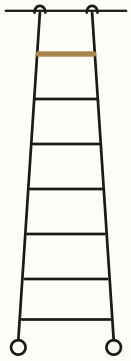
STOP

READ LAST

The Full Solution

This file names the culprit and explains every clue. Read it only after you have answered all three objectives, or if you have decided to give up on the case.

Inside: what really happened · the clue chain · why the other four are innocent · every red herring explained · DI Moss's closing letter



What Really Happened

September. Cornelius sent his treasure, the 1851 first edition of *The Marsh Clock*, to Rosalind Fenwick for a new binding (D10). Rosalind was struggling to keep Fenwick Bindery going. She kept the real first edition to sell privately and returned a copy of the 1852 second printing, beautifully bound so no one would look twice.

Wednesday, October 14. Cornelius checked the "points" of the first edition against his shelf list (D15): the 1851 date and the misprint "Clocke." The book on his shelf had neither. That night he wrote himself a private note in shelf marks (D14): SWAPPED · ASK · RF. In his diary he wrote "M.C.: checked the points. See note." (D11)

Thursday, 3:12 pm. He messaged Rosalind to come in at 9 on Friday about "the Marsh Clock job" (D18). Rosalind understood. At 3:25 pm she bought wheat-starch paste and a fine screwdriver at Harrow Bookbinding Supplies on her trade account (D17), then took the 3:50 bus to Little Wexham.

4:30 pm. She returned the Lantern Atlas, a top-shelf book (D15), knowing Cornelius would carry it up the ladder that evening. She left at 4:45 pm for the 4:50 bus, which did not run: schools were closed for a staff training day (D12, D16). She had read in the Courier that Cornelius would be at the library from 6 to 7 (D16).

About 6:00 pm. With the shop dark and locked, she came through the yard from Mill Lane in the rain, unlocked the back door and Door A with her key set 4 (D9), and left muddy prints on the freshly swept mat (D2, D6, D13). She climbed the ladder, turned out the two screws of the brass top rung, and took the swapped copy of the Marsh Clock so nobody could compare it with the shelf list. Paste from her fingers marked the rung, and the receipt slipped from her coat pocket under the ladder wheel (D2). She locked Door A again, left by the back door, and caught the 6:50 bus home (D12).

7:05 pm. Cornelius came back from his talk with Priya (D6). At 7:09 pm he messaged Imogen that he was putting the Lantern Atlas back on the top shelf (D18). The loosened rung gave way. He fell, and he never woke up.

Friday, 9:05 am. Rosalind arrived for the 9 o'clock meeting as if nothing had happened (D2), and told DI Moss she had caught the 4:50 bus (D8).

The Clue Chain

Seven steps, each tied to the exact document and line.

#	STEP	DOCS	WHERE TO LOOK
1	Rosalind says she caught the 4:50 pm bus home.	D8	"I left at quarter to five and caught the 4:50 bus home from the High Street stop."
2	That bus didn't run on Thursday, so her account is false. **(Objective 1)**	D12 D16	D12 note: "S = School days only… not on school staff training days." D16: "All Wexham Vale schools will be closed to pupils on Thursday, October 15."
3	The rung was safe at 4:15 pm, and Door A was watched until closing.	D6 D7	D6: "at quarter past he climbed back up to put it away. Steady as anything." "Mr. Q locked Door A behind them."
4	Someone came in by the back door after the rain began and before Cornelius returned at 7:05 pm. **(Objective 2)**	D2 D6 D13 D3 D18	D6: "I swept both doormats." D2: "muddy shoe prints pointing into the shop." D13: "5:40 pm, light rain begins." D18, 7:09 pm: "Putting the Lantern Atlas back up on the top shelf."
5	Only key sets can open both doors; set 3 stayed in the shop. Sets 2 and 4 were outside it.	D9 D2 D3	D9: set 4 "R. Fenwick… Returned: (blank)." Set 3 "on hook" at 5:30 pm and 8:52 am. D3: Imogen in Market Harrow 6:30–8:15 pm.
6	The receipt under the ladder is Rosalind's, from Thursday afternoon; the paste matches.	D17 D2 D8	D17: "Trade account: F.B. #0417… Wheat-starch paste… Screwdriver, fine 2.5mm." D2: residue "wheat-starch paste." D8: "I never went into the Rare Book Room yesterday."
7	Motive: Cornelius had found the swap and called her in. **(Objective 3)**	D14 D15 D11 D18 D10	D14 decodes to SWAPPED ASK RF. D11: "M.C.: checked the points." "9:00 R.F. (M.C. binding)." D18: "a word about the Marsh Clock job."

Decoding D14: 1·6·5 Notes on Pigeons → S · 5·6·4 The Weaver's Song → W · 1·5·7 Kettle and Hearth → A · 2·4·1 Pressed Flowers → P · 1·2·2 A Pocket Herbal → P · 5·5·1 Embers → E · 5·4·11 Poems of the Downs → D · 4·4·3 Sea Charts of the Channel → A · 3·1·1 Swallows over Kent → S · 5·2·1 Kingfisher Summer → K · 2·6·6 Quiet Rivers → R · 4·5·1 Ferns and Mosses → F

Why Not the Other Four?

SUSPECT	WHY THEY LOOKED GUILTY (RED HERRINGS)	WHAT RULES THEM OUT
Imogen Quillfeather	Wants to sell to Pageturner; holds key set 2; Cornelius planned to "change the partnership papers" (D4, D11, D16).	Seen boarding the 5:50 pm bus (D6); in a meeting in Market Harrow 6:30–8:15 pm (D3). The next bus back reached Little Wexham at 7:20 pm (D12), after Cornelius had already climbed.
Theo Marchetti	Lost the Marsh Clock at auction; "That book should have been mine"; outside the shop at 7:05 pm (D5, D6).	Running his book club with 11 members from 5:30 to 7:00 pm (D3, D16). He had no key set (D9).
Priya Halloran	Questioned about £400 from the till; signed out spare set 3 on Thursday; last to see Cornelius (D4, D9, D6).	The £400 was a deposit written twice (D10, D11). At the library talk with Cornelius from 6 to 7 pm (D3). Set 3 was back on its hook by 11:20 am (D9).
Desmond Achterberg	Refused at £18,000; "You'll regret this"; in the Rare Book Room at 4:15 pm; his card on the table (D7, D6, D2).	The rung was still safe when Cornelius climbed at 4:15 pm (D6). In the library from 5:48 to about 7:15 pm (D3). No key set (D9).

Other red herrings, explained

- **The missing Marsh Clock** pointed at the two people who wanted it most, Theo and Desmond. In fact it was taken because it was the swapped copy: without it, nobody could prove the swap.
- **Mr. Barnaby and the "partnership papers"** (D11, D4): Cornelius planned to protect the shop from a sale, a worry for Imogen but not a reason to harm him that night.
- **Theo's line about collectors** (D5) and Rosalind's pointing at Desmond (D8) are opinions, not evidence.
- **The till "shortfall"** (D4) was cleared up the day before (D10, D11).

Case Closed

Monday, October 19

Dear Detective,

Your report reached me on Saturday morning, and by Saturday afternoon we had our answer. Faced with the bus timetable, the clipping and her own receipt, Rosalind Fenwick told us everything. The real first edition of The Marsh Clock was wrapped in tissue at the back of her workshop, waiting for a private buyer. The swapped copy was in her gilding cupboard.

She has been charged. Imogen has asked that the Marsh Clock go back on the top shelf of Case R, where her uncle kept it, with a new ladder beneath it.

Priya is running the shop for now. Theo Marchetti sent flowers and a very long apology card. Desmond Achterberg has withdrawn his offer; he says some books should stay where they belong.

Thank you for trusting paper over people. If Little Wexham ever needs fresh eyes again, I know where to write.

With gratitude,

Harriet Moss

Detective Inspector Harriet Moss
Little Wexham CID

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